Dharmendra Rathore—were hatching another plan. Defying the high command, a majority of the MLAs assembled at Dhariwal's residence at the exact same time as the scheduled CLP meet. Kharge and Maken, deputed to oversee the crucial session, sat ashen-faced with Gehlot, the main beneficiary of this boycott, and finally returned empty-handed. Gehlot apologised to Sonia and withdrew from the presidential race. The party had no choice but to let him stay as CM. But almost as a face-saver, a show cause notice was served on the defiant trio.



Yet, two months on, no disciplinary action has been taken against them. Worse, the trio has been assigned the responsibility of coordinating Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra as it enters Rajasthan next month. Maken, a staunch Rahul campwallah, is understandably left riled. But Kharge, who too had to stomach the insult in person on September 25, as the MLAs thumbed their nose at the high command, has shown no urgency on that front after becoming president.

Kharge and Maken's divergent approaches are symptomatic of the gap between what can be loosely called the old guard and the young turks. Neither is a cohesive group in itself. The only difference is that the seniors, despite divergent views, back each other when it comes to matters of survival and maintaining status quo in the power structure. The juniors believe this grip of the veterans over the party's decision-making process is what holds back the Congress from advancing with a new narrative and energy. Though, at 61, Shashi Tharoor doesn't exactly qualify as a junior, the three-time Lok Sabha MP is being showcased as a classic case of what it means to be stonewalled by the veterans. Tharoor had contested against Kharge—who was unofficially backed by the Gandhis—in the presidential election, polling 1,072 of the total 9,000 votes. Yet, he has not been made a star campaigner in either Gujarat or Himachal Pradesh. Local Congress units are presently boycotting his events as he makes a foray in the northern parts of home state Kerala. The juniors say he is paying the price of challenging the status quo. The veterans summarily dismiss the idea, though. "I was an MP when I was not even 30," says a steering committee member. "I definitely understand the value of nurturing young blood. But I did not rush to become a minister; instead, I waited for my turn. The young ones must first perform, and rewards will come in due course."

THE VETERANS PREVAIL DUE TO THEIR FINANCIAL CLOUT, WHICH HELPS FUND THE BIG EVENTS

The younger lot cite the fate of Pilot and Jyotiraditya Scindia. As president of Rajasthan Congress, Pilot had led the party to victory in the 2018 assembly polls, but the CM's chair went to Gehlot. In Madhya Pradesh, Scindia was seen as the popular face, but the high command chose Kamal Nath. While Pilot attempted a coup in 2020, Scindia defected to the BJP and brought down the Kamal Nath regime. "In both cases, the late Ahmed Patel and a group of seniors like Ambika Soni and Mukul Wasnik prevailed upon the Gandhis. Even now, they keep saying Rajasthan will fall if Gehlot is removed. Congress will certainly lose next year if Gehlot continues. It may lose even under Pilot, but if a young leader is made the CM, it will at least galvanise other state units," says a former Union minister.

Of course, the lines are not always drawn according to age. The veterans cite the example of Himanta Biswa Sarma, whom several seniors, including Patel, backed but did not allow to replace Tarun Gogoi as Assam CM. "Even Sonia wanted Himanta as CM," says a Rajya Sabha MP. "But Rahul blocked the decision." Sarma defected to the BJP, who made him CM six years after he joined in 2015, allowing Sarbananda Sonowal to serve out a term.

The age lines get blurred even with debates on policy, but the gap plays into those. While all states barring West Bengal have implemented the New Pension Scheme (NPS), Congress-ruled Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh have decided to restore the Old Pension Scheme (OPS). In the run-up to the elections in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, the party has promised to revert to the OPS. One section of the party is unhappy with this. Praveen Chakravarty, who heads the party's data analytics department, tweeted: "Out of 65 million people in Gujarat, about 300,000 are in government service. The OPS will cost roughly 15 per cent of tax revenues. Why should the top 0.5 per cent of people get 15 per cent of all taxpayers' money?" Known for his proximity to Rahul and former PM Manmohan Singh, Chakravarty faced flak from several party colleagues, including Rajya Sabha MP and Congress general secretary in charge of communications Jairam Ramesh. Former finance minister P. Chidambaram, on the other hand, is